PROMISE & PRACTICE · DEEP DIVE · SOURCE ANALYSIS

The Election of 1864 — A House Divided

A Nation Votes on Whether to Keep Fighting

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

WHAT I CAN DO TODAY I can read primary sources about The Election of 1864 — A House Divided, weigh who made each one and why, and use evidence to answer historical questions.

Directions. Two platforms, one enormous question. Weigh the arguments and judge the choice

THE SOURCES

SOURCE A · THE DEMOCRATIC PLATFORM · 1864 — The case for peace

> *"… after four years of failure to restore the Union by the experiment of war … [we] demand that immediate efforts be made for a cessation of hostilities … that peace may be restored on the basis of the Federal Union of the States."*
> *— Democratic Party platform, 1864. Public domain*

— Democratic Party platform, 1864. Public domain.

SOURCE B · THE NATIONAL UNION PLATFORM · 1864 — The case for victory and abolition

> *"… we are in favor … of the complete suppression of the … Rebellion … [and] that … slavery … should be … prohibited throughout the … United States by an amendment to the Constitution."*
> *— National Union (Republican) platform, 1864. Public domain*

— National Union (Republican) platform, 1864. Public domain.

YOUR WORK

QUESTION 1 STEP 1 · LINE THEM UP

In your own words, what did each platform promise? What would a vote for McClellan (A) mean, and what would a vote for Lincoln (B) mean?

_____

_____

_____

QUESTION 2 STEP 2 · THE HIDDEN COST

Why would a negotiated peace in 1864 almost certainly have meant the survival of slavery?

- ☐ A. making peace meant recognizing the Confederacy, which existed to protect slavery
- ☐ B. the Democrats wanted more slavery in the North
- ☐ C. Lincoln had already lost the war
- ☐ D. peace had nothing to do with slavery

QUESTION 3 STEP 3 · THE SOLDIER VOTE

Soldiers had the most reason to want the war over, yet they voted about 3-to-1 for Lincoln. Explain why the men doing the fighting would vote to keep fighting.

QUESTION 4 STEP 4 · YOUR JUDGMENT

No nation had ever held a free election in the middle of a civil war. In three or four sentences, argue whether holding the 1864 election was wise or dangerous — and what it showed about American democracy.

TEACHER ANSWER KEY — The Election of 1864 — A House Divided

QUESTION 1: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "A (McClellan) promised... B (Lincoln) promised..."

QUESTION 2: **Correct — A. making peace meant recognizing the Confederacy, which existed to protect slavery**

Right. Stopping the war short of victory would have meant recognizing the Confederacy — and the Confederacy existed to protect slavery. Peace meant slavery survived.

QUESTION 3: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "The soldiers voted for Lincoln because..."

QUESTION 4: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "Holding the election was ___ because..."